



CITY RELOCATION GUIDE • AUSTRALIA

Brisbane

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Brisbane.

Ethicare Resourcing

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ethicareresourcing.com

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This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Welcome to Brisbane

Brisbane Guide · Chapter 1 of 9



Brisbane is the Australian city that has quietly stopped being a compromise. Two and a half million people, a rebuilt centre, tertiary medicine along the river, and the arithmetic that Sydney lost a decade ago: a family house, a short commute, and a winter you actively look forward to.

A city organised by its river

The Brisbane River loops through everything here, and it does the organising. The CBD sits inside one bend; South Bank faces it across the water with the state gallery, the museum and a swimming lagoon on a former expo site. Ferries are public transport, not sightseeing. The old inner suburbs — New Farm, Paddington, West End, Bulimba — ring the centre within four or five kilometres, full of timber Queenslanders on stumps with wide verandahs built for exactly this climate.

For clinicians the draw is a genuine cluster: tertiary and quaternary services concentrated close to the city, teaching hospitals with university partnerships, and the fastest-growing health demand in the country in the corridors north and south. Registration is national, but hiring here runs service by service, so “a job in Brisbane” is really a job in one part of a metro area 100 kilometres across.

The honest costs are the summer and the transport. December to March is humid, stormy and long — air conditioning is infrastructure. And while the train, busway and ferry spines are good, the gaps between them are thin: most households here keep a car.

Who wrote this

We’re a healthcare recruitment company, so we have an interest — but this guide isn’t a pitch. There’s nothing in it asking you to register, no form, and no visa advice.

Brisbane is the city we most often recommend to families, and the one candidates most often treat as a stepping stone to Sydney. This guide argues it deserves better than that — and says plainly where it doesn’t.

The city, in nine numbers

~2.5M

In Greater Brisbane — Australia’s third-largest city, and its fastest-growing capital by a clear margin.

21°

The average July day. Dry, blue and shirtsleeve — the single most persuasive fact about living here.

~30°

And humid, January to March, with an afternoon storm season that is genuinely theatrical.

20 km

Inland from the sea, on a tidal river — the beaches are a drive, not a walk. Locals plan around that.

1 hr

To the Gold Coast south, or the Sunshine Coast north. Two entirely different beach cultures, both a day trip.

2032

The Olympics — and, more usefully, a decade of hospital, transport and housing investment already under way.

3rd

Busiest international gateway in the country, twenty minutes from the city by train.

UTC+10

No daylight saving. Summer light from 4.45am, dark by seven — early starts come naturally.

~1,300

Square kilometres in the local government area alone — one of the largest in the country. This is a spread-out city.



Parkland, poincianas and the towers behind — the city is greener than its reputation.

Six things you only learn once you're here

Winter is the whole argument

Ten weeks of dry, still, 21-degree days while Melbourne shivers. It resets what you think a year feels like, and it is why the southerners keep arriving.

Summer is the price

Humidity you wear rather than feel, storms that arrive at four and clear by six, and January errands done before ten. Everyone adapts; nobody pretends they enjoy February.

The Queenslander earns its keep

High stumps, wide verandahs, cross-breezes and shade – a house designed for this climate before air conditioning existed. Living in one teaches you the weather.

The ferry is a commute

CityCats are ordinary public transport, on the same card as the trains. Living near a terminal is a genuine housing strategy here.

No daylight saving is real

Light at 4.45am in summer, dark by seven. Sport, gyms and coffee all start earlier than you expect. Queenslanders vote to keep it and enjoy the argument.

It is not a stepping stone

People arrive planning three years and a move south. Most stop planning that around the time they buy a house within half an hour of work.

A note on Country

Brisbane stands on the lands of the Turrbal and Jagera peoples, and Meanjin is the name you will increasingly see alongside Brisbane. The river, the bends and the crossing points carry names and meanings that predate the colonial city by many thousands of years.

Acknowledgement of Country opens meetings, and health services work in partnership with Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander community-controlled organisations. Torres Strait Islander health is a significant part of the Queensland system. Take the cultural induction seriously.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all of them about Brisbane specifically. Topics that are true across the state – the sixteen hospital and health services, the regional and tropical north – sit in the [Queensland guide](#). Anything true of Australia generally – Medicare, visas, Ahpra registration, tax, superannuation, schools – lives once in [Moving to Australia](#).

If you read nothing else, read [Why Brisbane](#) for the full case including the reasons people choose Sydney or Melbourne, and [Where clinicians live](#), because in a metro area this large the suburb decides the life.

Why Brisbane

Brisbane Guide · Chapter 2 of 9



Brisbane has spent thirty years being described by what it isn't. This chapter does the opposite: what the river city actually gives a working clinician, what a week here plausibly looks like — and when we'd point you south instead.

The arithmetic

Write the sum down and Brisbane usually wins it. Tertiary and quaternary medicine sits within a few kilometres of the centre, so you are not trading clinical depth for lifestyle. Around that, a three-bedroom house in a genuine inner-ring suburb costs a fraction of the Sydney equivalent, and buying one on a clinical salary is a plan rather than a fantasy. Commutes are measured in twenties, not hours. And the corridors north and south carry the fastest-growing health demand in the country, which means real choice about where you work.

Pay follows Queensland awards and enterprise agreements, broadly in the national range — we quote no figures in this guide and will always walk you through the current agreement for your profession instead. The point is not that you earn more here. It is that the same career buys more life, and keeps the tertiary work.

21°

The average July day

~30 min

Inner-ring suburb to a tertiary campus

2

Coasts within an hour, in either direction

A typical week

A week here holds all of this without effort. A shift that starts after a twenty-minute drive or a ferry down the river. A swim in the South Bank lagoon or a lap of the Kangaroo Point cliffs before the heat arrives. Thursday night at a West End restaurant that would be booked out for a month in Sydney. Saturday morning at a farmers' market under a highway, then the bay: a ferry to Moreton or the sand islands, dolphins on the way over. Sunday in the Scenic Rim or up at Mount Coot-tha before the storm builds.

In winter the same week barely changes shape, because winter is the season the city is built for — outdoor tables, dry mornings, the football, and no coat. That is the part visitors underestimate.

Moreton Bay — a ferry ride, not a holiday

Sophie's insight

Brisbane is the easiest Australian city to recommend to a family, and the one candidates most often underestimate. They arrive expecting a stepping stone to Sydney, then discover they can buy a house, keep the tertiary work, and be at the bay or the range by ten on a Saturday.

My one caution: visit in February if you can, not July. If you can live with the summer, the other ten months are the best value in the country.

Sophie Careem Founder & CEO, Ethicare Resourcing

When we'd point you south instead

The summer is genuinely hard

Four months of heat and humidity, with a storm season on top. If you wilt in it – or have family who will – that is a real objection, not a detail.

Sydney and Melbourne are bigger systems

More tertiary sites, deeper sub-specialty benches, more research. A narrow sub-specialty or a very specific fellowship may simply have more room there.

It is a spread-out city

A metro area 100 km across with good spines and thin gaps. Get the suburb wrong and you will drive far more than you planned.

Housing is no longer cheap

Cheaper than Sydney, yes – but Brisbane has had the fastest price growth of any capital. The bargain of 2015 is not the bargain of today.

The beach is a drive

Twenty kilometres inland. If you want sand at the end of the street, the Gold or Sunshine Coast is the honest answer – and both have their own hospitals.

Where we'd steer you instead

If you want the beach at the door with a real hospital attached, look at the coasts either side – the [Queensland guide](#) covers both corridors.

If you need maximum system scale, [New South Wales](#) or [Victoria](#) carry more tertiary sites.

If it is cost of living that decides it, [South Australia](#) is the most affordable mainland capital and Adelaide still runs major hospitals.

In our experience

Brisbane suits clinicians who want capital-city medicine without capital-city overheads – the system has genuine depth, and the lifestyle spend goes further. The people who settle best make peace with summer early and plan their year around the other eight months.

Brisbane at a glance

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Before the practical chapters, orientation. Brisbane is not a grid and not a strip — it is a river city built across ridges, which is why two suburbs four kilometres apart can feel like different towns, and why the map repays ten minutes of study before you choose a rental.

How the city is laid out

The river and the centre

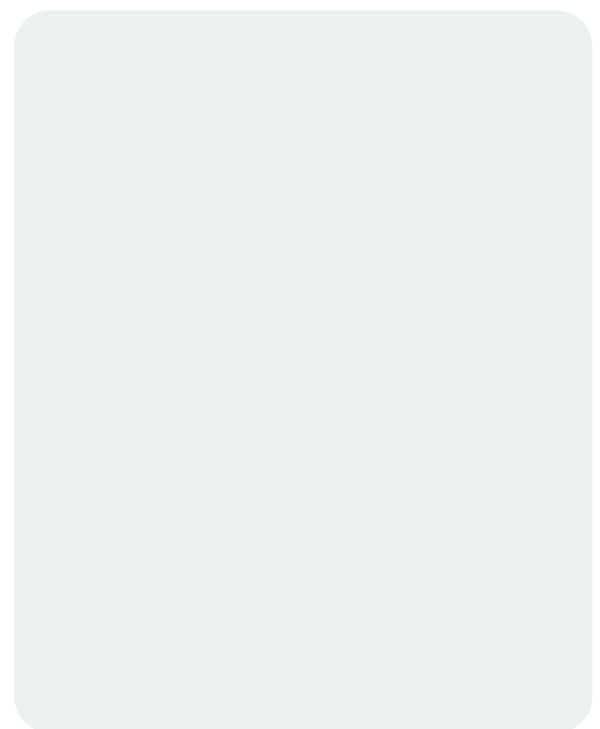
The CBD sits in a tight bend, with South Bank facing it across the water — gallery, museum, a swimming lagoon, and the Goodwill Bridge carrying walkers and cyclists between the two. This is where the tertiary hospital work concentrates, and where the ferry network is densest. Kangaroo Point's cliffs, Story Bridge and the New Farm reach are all within a few minutes of it.

The inner ring

Four to six kilometres out in every direction: Paddington and Bardon up the western ridges, New Farm and Teneriffe on the river, West End in its own bend, Bulimba and Hawthorne east, Wilston and Windsor north. Timber Queenslanders, corner cafés, and a genuine walkable life. This is where most clinicians start and many stay.

The corridors and the bay

Beyond that the city runs a long way: the growth corridors north toward the Sunshine Coast and south toward the Gold Coast, the bayside suburbs east at Wynnum and Manly with Moreton Bay in front of them, Ipswich and the valley west. The metro area is roughly a hundred kilometres across, so the corridor you pick matters as much as the suburb.



Where Brisbane sits, with the straight-line distance to Sunshine Coast and Gold Coast

A subtropical year

Two seasons matter here, and the shoulder months are a gift. Summer, December to March, is hot and humid with a genuine afternoon storm season and most of the year's rain. Winter, June to August, is the reason people move: dry, still, blue, around 21 degrees, and cool enough at night for a jumper. Spring and autumn are simply pleasant, and jacaranda season in late spring turns whole streets purple.

Summer
Dec – Feb
21–30°
Humid · storm season
Autumn
Mar – May
16–27°
The pay-off begins
Winter
Jun – Aug
10–21°
Dry, blue, shirtsleeve
Spring
Sep – Nov
15–27°
Jacarandas · building heat

Two practical notes. Air conditioning is not a luxury in a Brisbane summer — make it a rental criterion, and ask about ceiling fans and cross-breezes too, because a well-designed Queenslanders does half the work. And take the storm season seriously: hail, flash flooding and power cuts are normal, and the city has a long memory of river flooding, so check a property's flood history before you sign anything.

The clock

Queensland runs on UTC+10 and does not observe daylight saving. In summer that means light from about 4.45am and dark by seven, so mornings are when the city lives: gyms, swims, dog walks and coffee all start early, and evening plans start earlier than southerners expect. It also means Brisbane sits an hour behind Sydney and Melbourne for four months of the year — worth remembering for interstate meetings and family calls.

Getting in and out

Brisbane Airport is the country's third international gateway, about twenty minutes from the city on the Airtrain, with direct flights across Asia and the Pacific and to every Australian capital. By road, the Gold Coast is an hour south, the Sunshine Coast an hour north, and the northern rivers of New South Wales a comfortable weekend. Sydney is a 90-minute flight; Melbourne just over two hours.

Words you'll hear in week one

MeanjinThe Turrbal name for the Brisbane city area — increasingly used alongside Brisbane
QueenslanderThe timber, high-stumped, verandahed house the city is built from
CityCatThe river ferry — ordinary public transport, on the same card as the trains
The ValleyFortitude Valley — music, late nights and Chinatown, ten minutes from the CBD
Go cardThe tap-on card for trains, buses and ferries across south-east Queensland
The CoastEither the Gold or the Sunshine — context tells you which, and locals are loyal
Storm seasonRoughly November to March: hail, flash flooding, and a very good light show
Bris-vegasAn old, affectionate nickname — used ironically now the city has grown up

Healthcare in Brisbane

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Registration is national; hiring here is service by service. Brisbane's advantage is concentration — tertiary and quaternary medicine within a few kilometres of the river, with the country's fastest-growing demand in the corridors either side. This chapter explains the shape of it without naming employers.

How the metro system is organised

Queensland runs its public system as sixteen hospital and health services statewide; several of them cover Greater Brisbane, split broadly between the inner city, the northern side and the southern side, with a statewide children's service alongside them. Each service employs in its own right, so moving between them later is a fresh application rather than a transfer — and “a job in Brisbane” means a job in one part of a metro area a hundred kilometres across.

Alongside the public services sit a substantial private hospital sector, a large private imaging and pathology market, university-linked research institutes clustered near the tertiary campuses, and Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander community-controlled health organisations.

Tertiary, close in

The major teaching and quaternary services sit within a few kilometres of the CBD, on both sides of the river — including the state's most complex adult and paediatric work.

Two growth corridors

North toward the Sunshine Coast and south toward the Gold Coast: the fastest-growing catchments in Australia, with new capacity and steady recruitment.

A statewide children's service

Paediatric specialist care runs as its own service from Brisbane, taking referrals from the whole state and northern New South Wales.

One national register

Ahpra registration works everywhere in Australia. The process, English evidence and assessment live once in [Eligibility & registration](#).

Laid out the way the metro area actually runs – north to south, either side of the river. Each of these employs in its own right, so where you apply is also where you commute for the next several years.

The northern corridor

Toward the Sunshine Coast · one of the fastest-growing catchments in Australia, with new capacity coming on and steady recruitment behind it

The northern side

Its own service, its own campuses – secondary and community work alongside the growth the corridor is pushing south into the city

Inner Brisbane, both banks

The teaching and quaternary campuses, within a few kilometres of the CBD – the state's most complex adult work, with the statewide children's service alongside it

The southern side

Its own service again, its own campuses – a large and still-growing catchment on the far bank from the inner-city cluster

The southern corridor

Toward the Gold Coast · the other fast-growing catchment, and the other end of a metro area roughly a hundred kilometres across

Moving between services later is a fresh application rather than a transfer – which is why the side of the river matters before the rental does. [Where clinicians live](#) works through the commute properly.

What that means for a career

Brisbane is the one Australian city where you can generally have both: quaternary-level work and a house within half an hour of it. Sub-specialty benches are deep enough for most fellowships and narrower than Sydney's or Melbourne's for a few — if your field is very narrow, ask us early and we will tell you honestly whether the bench here is wide enough.

The 2032 Olympics matter less as a sporting event than as a decade of committed infrastructure: hospital expansion, transport, and housing supply, all of it already under way. For a clinician planning a fifteen-year career rather than a three-year stint, that pipeline is the substantive argument.

Two structural notes worth knowing. Queensland's regional and tropical services — Townsville, Cairns and the central coast — run tertiary-level medicine a long way from the capital, and they recruit hard; the [Queensland guide](#) covers that properly. And Brisbane, unlike the state's regional centres, is not classed as regional for skilled migration, which changes the visa arithmetic — see [Visas & the move](#).

“

Quaternary work, and a house half an hour from it. Brisbane is the city where that sentence is still true.

The one-line version

What to ask at interview

Pay follows Queensland awards and enterprise agreements — we deliberately quote no figures in this guide, and will walk you through the current agreement for your profession instead. What you can pin down at interview:

Salary packaging — public-health roles can package part of your pay pre-tax; ask how much and how to start it on day one

Which service, and which campus — the same job title means different work across a metro area this size

The roster reality — shift patterns, penalties, on-call frequency and how gaps are covered

Public, private or both — and what rights of private practice exist in your profession

CPD — funded time and money, and whether interstate conference travel is included

Supervision and support in your first year, especially if you trained overseas

Parking and the commute at your actual shift times — free parking is not a given on the inner campuses

Professional indemnity — what the employer covers and what stays yours

Two things to do early

Start registration as soon as Brisbane is on your shortlist — paperwork, not ambition, is what moves start dates. And decide your side of the river before you look at rentals: the service that hires you sets your commute for years, and crossing the city twice a day is the one avoidable mistake here.

Where clinicians live

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In a metro area a hundred kilometres across, the suburb decides the life. The good news is that Brisbane's inner ring is unusually generous — character housing four kilometres from tertiary campuses — and the honest news is that it is no longer cheap. Here is the map as we'd draw it over coffee.

ON THE MAP

THE INNER NORTH

- 1 New Farm
- 3 Wilston
- 5 Ashgrove
- 7 Bardon
- 2 Teneriffe
- 4 Windsor
- 6 Paddington

THE INNER SOUTH

- 8 West End
- 10 Dutton Park
- 12 Moorooka
- 9 Highgate Hill
- 11 Annerley
- 13 Tarragindi

EAST, WEST & BAYSIDE

- 14 Bulimba
- 16 Norman Park
- 18 Manly
- 20 Kenmore
- 15 Hawthorne
- 17 Wynnum
- 19 Indooroopilly
- 21 Ipswich

THE TWO COASTS

- 22 Gold Coast
- 23 Sunshine Coast

 Parks & nature  Beaches  Landmarks

Shaded areas are the suburbs named in this chapter. Arrows point to places beyond the map edge, with the straight-line distance from the city centre.

Suburb boundaries © Geoscape Australia, CC BY 4.0 · Natural Earth

The inner north

New Farm and Teneriffe sit on the river bend: converted woolstores, the best restaurant strip in the city, a ferry terminal and prices to match. Behind them, Wilston, Windsor and Ashgrove are the classic Queenslander family suburbs – timber houses on stumps, good state schools, ten to fifteen minutes from the inner campuses. Paddington and Bardon climb the western ridges: antique shops, steep streets, views, and a village feel five minutes from the CBD.

The inner south

West End is the city's most characterful pocket – markets, Greek and Vietnamese food, a bend of the river and a stubbornly independent streak. Highgate Hill and Dutton Park sit above it, close to the southern tertiary cluster and the university. Further out, Annerley, Moorooka and Tarragindi are the sensible-value belt: solid houses, decent buses, and change from the inner-north price.

East, west and bayside

Bulimba, Hawthorne and Norman Park run east along the river – family-heavy, ferry-served, quietly expensive. Keep going and you reach the bayside proper: Wynnum and Manly, where the water is Moreton Bay rather than surf, the pace drops noticeably, and the money goes considerably further. West, Indooroopilly and Kenmore give big blocks and good schools with a longer commute; further out, Ipswich is a city in its own right with its own hospital and the most affordable housing in the metro area.

The two coasts, honestly

Plenty of clinicians skip Brisbane entirely and choose a coast. The Gold Coast, an hour south, is Australia's sixth-largest city with a major tertiary hospital and the beach at the end of the street; the Sunshine Coast, an hour north, pairs surf towns with one of the newest hospital precincts in the country. Both are genuine career bases, not compromises. What you give up is Brisbane's concentration of quaternary work and the shortest commutes – and commuting daily between the coasts and the city is a mistake people make once.

The honest comparison

Fastest

Capital-city price growth in Australia recently

4 wks

Maximum bond, plus up to two weeks in advance

Check

Flood history before you sign – always, on this river

If you want...	Consider	Because
Walk to the tertiary campuses	Wilston, Windsor, Dutton Park	Ten minutes, character housing, good schools
Restaurants and the river	New Farm, Teneriffe	Ferry at the door – and the highest inner prices
Village life with views	Paddington, Bardon	Ridge streets, five minutes from town
Character on a budget	West End, Annerley, Moorooka	Inner south, real value, strong food culture
Family space and water	Bulimba, Wynnum, Manly	Bayside pace, ferries, more house per dollar
Maximum affordability	Ipswich and the west	Its own hospital, the cheapest metro housing
The beach at the door	Gold or Sunshine Coast	Real tertiary hospitals, an hour from the city

Renting itself – applications, bonds, rights, the documents that win a tight market – works the same across Australia and lives once in [Living in Australia](#). Two Brisbane-specific habits: check flood history and mapping for any property near the river or a creek, and treat air conditioning plus cross-breezes as a search criterion rather than a bonus.

Before you sign a lease

Which side of the river is your campus – and does the commute cross the city at peak?

What is the flood history, and what do the council flood maps say about this exact address?

Air conditioning, ceiling fans, cross-breezes: how does this house handle February?

Is it in the state-school catchment you need? Zones run street by street.

Would a short-term rental first be wiser? Most people re-choose once they know the city.

Getting around

Brisbane Guide · Chapter 6 of 9



Brisbane's transport is better than its reputation and patchier than a European city's. The spines — rail, busway and river — are good. Between them it thins out fast. Choose your suburb with that in mind and you may not need a second car.

The network, in four parts

Go card

One tap-on card (or a contactless bank card) across trains, buses and ferries in south-east Queensland, with fares capped by zone and cheaper off-peak.

Rail

Radial lines out through the suburbs and down both coasts, plus the Airtrain to the terminals. Excellent if you live on a line; irrelevant if you don't.

Busways

Brisbane's real innovation: dedicated bus-only roads with tunnels and stations, so buses skip the traffic entirely. Fast, frequent, and the backbone of the inner south.

CityCats

The river ferries are ordinary commuting, not sightseeing — fast, frequent and the nicest twenty minutes of anyone's working day. Living near a terminal is a genuine strategy.

The city is also unusually good for cycling along the river: the bikeways, the Goodwill Bridge and the Riverwalk make a genuine commuting network, at least outside the summer months when arriving dry becomes ambitious.

Driving here

Australians drive on the left. Brisbane is easy to drive by capital-city standards — no grid, plenty of river crossings, and traffic that would make a Sydneysider laugh — but it does have toll roads and tunnels, and the airport link is one of them, so a toll account is worth setting up early. Licence transfer and buying a car work the same across the country and live in [Living in Australia](#).

Two local notes. Storm season brings flash flooding on low crossings: never drive into water, and learn which route out of your suburb stays open. And parking at the inner-city hospital campuses is genuinely tight — ask about staff parking at interview rather than assuming.

Distances that actually matter

From the CBD to...	Roughly	How
The inner ring (New Farm, West End, Paddington)	5–15 min	Bus, ferry, bike
Brisbane Airport	~20 min	Airtrain or toll road
Bayside (Wynnum, Manly)	~30 min	Rail
Ipswich	~40 min	Rail
Gold Coast	~1 hr	Rail then light rail, or drive
Sunshine Coast	~1 hr 15	Drive; rail to Nambour
Scenic Rim / hinterland	1–1.5 hrs	Drive
Sydney	~90 min	Fly

The takeaway

Pick a home on a rail line, a busway or a ferry terminal and Brisbane works without a daily drive. Pick one between the spines and you will own two cars within six months. That single decision matters more here than in any other Australian capital.

Cost of living

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Brisbane's old pitch was simple: Sydney weather, half the price. The first half still holds. The second needs honesty — this has been the fastest-rising capital in the country, and the bargain of ten years ago is not the bargain of today. Here is the audit.

Why there are no prices on this page

We used to print a weekly rent and a monthly budget table here. We have taken them out. A figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later, and a candidate who plans a move around a stale number is worse off than one who plans around none.

What does not go stale is the *shape* of a month, and the judgement about which lines will surprise you — which is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Brisbane against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

The headline

Below

Sydney and Melbourne on housing, clearly

Fastest

Capital-city price growth in recent years

~30 min

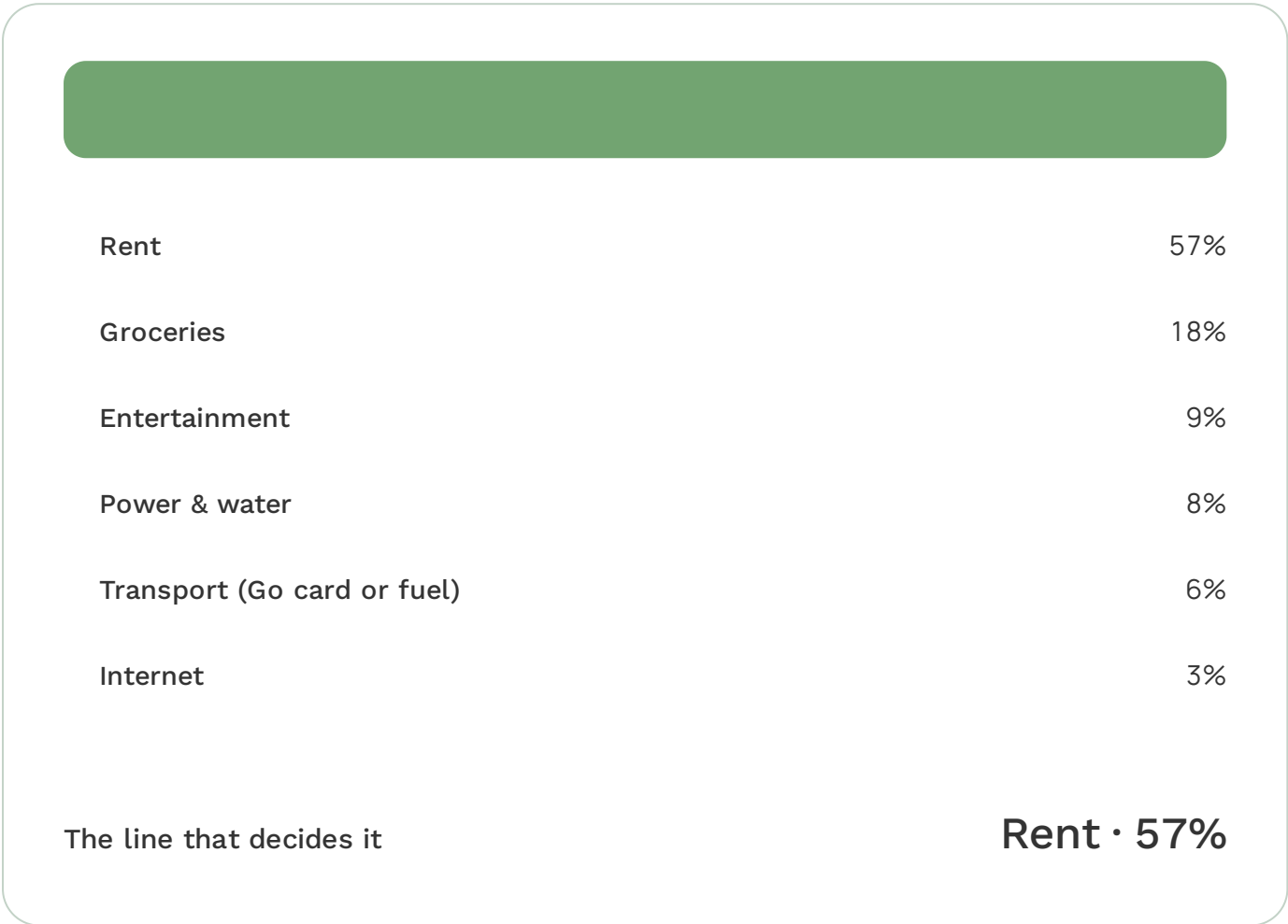
What that money still buys in commute terms

The structural point holds: a family house in a real inner-ring suburb, within half an hour of tertiary work, is achievable here on a clinical salary. That sentence is no longer true of Sydney.

What everyday life costs

WHERE A MONTH ACTUALLY GOES

The proportions, for one person on a mid-range budget. Proportions move slowly; prices move every quarter. Rent takes just under sixty per cent – still below Sydney, no longer the bargain of ten years ago.



Sydney weather at this rent line is the half of the old pitch that still holds. This has been the fastest-rising capital in the country, so treat the top of that range as the live number rather than the bottom.

The three costs the winter hides

Summer power

Four months of air conditioning is a real line on the bill, and it lands in the quarter when everything else costs more too. A well-designed home – shade, fans, cross-breezes – genuinely changes the number.

The car, and the tolls

Unless you live on a rail line, busway or ferry route, most households run a car and many run two. Brisbane also has toll roads and tunnels, including the airport link, so a toll account joins the list.

Insurance

Storm, hail and flood risk make Queensland home and contents insurance dearer than the southern states, and flood-prone addresses dearer again. Get a quote for the specific address before you commit to it.

Where the money comes back

Housing is the big one: the gap against Sydney funds most of the rest of the life. Then the small ones accumulate – commutes short enough to save childcare hours, a winter with no heating bill at all, weekend entertainment that is mostly free because it is a bay, a river and a range, and produce that is grown a couple of hours away rather than trucked across a continent.

On the income side, public-health and not-for-profit roles here can salary-package part of your pay before tax. Ask payroll on day one – many international staff set it up months later than they should. How packaging, tax and superannuation work is national and lives in [Pay & conditions](#).

The bottom line

Plan the bridge as well as the destination: temporary accommodation, a bond of up to four weeks' rent plus up to two weeks in advance, a car, and setting up a home in a climate that needs cooling. It costs less here than an east-coast capital move – but the people who arrive calm are the ones who priced it first.

Get today's numbers, and compare them to home

These are live and updated continuously, which is why we send you to them rather than competing with them. Put the city you are leaving in the other box.

Numbeo cost-of-living calculator (<https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/>) – the most complete comparison tool, and the one most clinicians already use. Crowd-sourced, so read it as a ballpark rather than a quote.

Expatistan (<https://www.expatistan.com/cost-of-living>) – the same idea with a cleaner side-by-side. Worth running as a sanity check when Numbeo looks off.

Australian Bureau of Statistics (<https://www.abs.gov.au/statistics/economy/price-indexes-and-inflation>) – official, slower, and the one to trust on the direction of travel rather than any single price.

If what you find contradicts the judgement on this page, tell us. We would rather correct the page than defend it.

Food, coffee & the everyday

Brisbane Guide · Chapter 8 of 9



Brisbane runs on an early clock and eats outdoors. The heat wrote both rules: the city gets its living done in the morning, and its restaurants long ago worked out that a verandah beats a dining room for ten months of the year.

The weekly rhythm

Saturday morning is the fixed point. The Jan Powers markets at New Farm and the Powerhouse, the sprawling Davies Park market under the trees at West End, and the Milton and Northey Street growers' markets all trade early and finish by lunch — because by lunch in summer nobody wants to be standing in a car park. Buy fruit you have never seen before; the subtropics grow things the southern states can only import.

For the rest: Woolworths and Coles everywhere, ALDI for the cheap basket, and — this being Queensland — independent grocers and butchers that still hold their own on the suburban high streets. The bakery order that marks you as local is a curried scallop pie in the south of the state, but in Brisbane it is simply anything eaten before nine.

Everything is early

No daylight saving means light at 4.45am. Gyms, swims, dog parks, coffee queues and park runs all happen at an hour southerners find alarming.

The verandah rule

Almost every good venue is open-sided. Book the outside table year-round, except during a storm, when the whole city watches from under an awning.

Coffee is serious

Brisbane roasts properly and doesn't make a religion of it — the standard is high, the queues are quick and nobody quizzes you.

Mangoes are an event

Summer arrives with Bowen mangoes by the tray, lychees, custard apples and finger limes. The fruit is the compensation for February.

Where the neighbourhoods eat

West End is the heart of it: Greek since the fifties, Vietnamese since the seventies, and now a strip of small bars and restaurants with the best value in the city. Fortitude Valley and its Chinatown carry the late nights and the live music; James Street in New Farm and Teneriffe is the polished end; Bulimba's Oxford Street and Paddington's Given Terrace are the neighbourhood versions. South Bank feeds the crowds along the river, and the inner-city hospital campuses are all a short walk from something decent.

For flavours of home, Brisbane is well served for its size: the Vietnamese and Chinese grocers around Inala and Sunnybank in the south, halal butchers and Middle Eastern and African stores across the western and southern suburbs, and Indian and Sri Lankan grocers spread through the growth corridors. Sunnybank is the destination worth the drive — several malls of excellent Asian food and produce.

The social calendar

Winter is when the city is outdoors constantly: the Ekka in August (the Royal Queensland Show, and a public holiday for the city), Riverfire and the Brisbane Festival in September, night markets, outdoor cinema, and football that fills the stadium. Summer flips it: the beach, the pool, the air-conditioned gallery, and an afternoon storm to watch. Learn the rhythm and the climate stops being a problem.

The everyday, in one list

Saturday market before nine — New Farm, Davies Park, Northey Street or Milton.

Cheapest basket: ALDI. Best produce: the markets. Best Asian food and groceries: Sunnybank.

Book the outside table. Everything social happens outdoors here, and early.

Eat the summer fruit. It is the single best thing about the hard season.

Bay, hinterland & two coasts

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Brisbane's weekend geography is unusually generous: a bay full of sand islands to the east, mountains and rainforest to the west and south, and two entirely different beach cultures an hour either way. Most of it is close enough to do after a Saturday morning shift.

The bay

Moreton Bay is the thing visitors miss and residents organise their lives around. Moreton Island — Mulgumpin — is the world's third-largest sand island, reachable by vehicle ferry, with wrecks to snorkel, dunes to sandboard and wild dolphins in the shallows at dusk. North Stradbroke — Minjerribah — is the surf-and-headland one, with whales passing close from June. Both are day trips, not holidays.

Closer in, the bayside suburbs give you the water without the ferry: Wynnum and Manly's esplanades, the mangrove boardwalks at Nudgee and Boondall, and the tidal flats where the migratory shorebirds arrive from Siberia each spring.

The hinterland

West and south the land climbs quickly. The Scenic Rim — Lamington, Springbrook, Mount Barney — holds Gondwana rainforest, waterfalls and walking tracks an hour and a half from the CBD, cool enough to need a jumper in July. Closer still, Mount Coot-tha does the sunset view over the city, and the Glass House Mountains stand up out of the plain on the way north. The Sunshine Coast hinterland — Maleny, Montville — is the weekend-away version: ridge-top villages, cheese, and a view back to the sea.

Two coasts, two cultures

South is the Gold Coast: high-rises, a genuine surf strip, theme parks and the most famous beaches in the country, an hour by rail or road. North is the Sunshine Coast: lower-rise, greener, family-shaped, with Noosa's national park headland and main beach at its top end and a string of surf towns below it. Brisbane people are loyal to one or the other and will tell you which at length. Try both before you take sides.

THREE DIRECTIONS OUT OF THE CITY

Brisbane's weekend geography is unusually generous, and it runs on three axes. Most of what follows is close enough to do after a Saturday morning shift.

East, to the bay

The thing visitors miss and residents organise their lives around — sand islands, wrecks to snorkel, and whales passing close from June.

The city	Bayside · 30 min by rail	Vehicle ferry	Moreton & Stradbroke
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West and south, up into the range

The land climbs quickly: Gondwana rainforest, waterfalls and walking tracks cool enough to need a jumper in July.

The city	Mount Coot-tha · 15 min	Scenic Rim · ~1 hr 30	Lamington
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The two coasts, an hour either way

South for high-rises and the most famous surf in the country; north for lower-rise, greener and family-shaped. Locals pick one and will tell you which at length.

The city	Gold Coast · ~1 hr	Sunshine Coast · ~1 hr 15	Noosa · ~1 hr 30
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The Gold Coast run is a rail journey as well as a drive, which matters on a long weekend when the M1 fills. Try both coasts before you take sides.

Ten weekends, to start

Moreton Island: the Tangalooma wrecks, the dunes and dolphins at dusk
North Stradbroke: the Gorge Walk, then whale-watching from the headland in winter
Lamington National Park: rainforest circuits and the tree-top walk
Noosa: the national park coastal track, then breakfast on Hastings Street
Springbrook and Purling Brook Falls, with glow-worms after dark
Mount Coot-tha at sunset, and the botanic gardens below it
The Glass House Mountains and a Maleny ridge-top lunch

A CityCat the length of the river, just because it is the best fare in Australia

Bayside: the Wynnum esplanade, the mangrove boardwalks and fish and chips

The Gold Coast: Burleigh Heads point at dawn, before the crowds

That's the guide

Nine chapters on Brisbane. Statewide topics — the sixteen health services, the tropical north — live in the [Queensland guide](#), and everything national in [Moving to Australia](#). When you're ready to talk about real roles here, [we're easy to reach](#) — and there's no pipeline waiting on the other end of the call.